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October 17, 1986

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TO: GOP LEADERS

FROM: Republican Policy Committee

SUBJECT: Talking Points on SDI

Last week we sent you a copy of our "End of Session" Talking Points on the Economy & GOP Control of the Senate.

Enclosed here are some Talking Points on the Iceland Summit and SDI.

Please let us know if you need additional copies.

DEPARTMENT OF STATE A/CDC/MR

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Date *11/14/89*

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24 OCT 1986

10/17/86

REPUBLICANS SUPPORT PRESIDENT REAGAN AND S.D.I.

SUMMARY

IN 1983 PRESIDENT REAGAN PROPOSED HIS STRATEGIC DEFENSE INITIATIVE (S.D.I.), A NON-NUCLEAR DEFENSE AGAINST SOVIET NUCLEAR MISSILES.

EVER SINCE, LIBERAL DEMOCRATS IN THE CONGRESS HAVE BEEN TRYING TO KILL S.D.I., WHILE SENATE REPUBLICANS HAVE STOOD WITH THE PRESIDENT AND HIS PROGRAM TO DEFEND THE AMERICAN PEOPLE.

IN ICELAND, THE SOVIETS DEMANDED THAT THE UNITED STATES KILL S.D.I. AS THEIR PRICE FOR AGREEING TO MUTUAL ARMS CUTS. THE PRESIDENT REFUSED TO GIVE UP OUR RIGHT TO DEFEND OURSELVES. S.D.I., HE SAID, IS OUR "INSURANCE POLICY" AGAINST SOVIET CHEATING.

NOW THE AMERICAN PEOPLE FACE A SIMPLE BUT HISTORIC DECISION: WILL THEY ELECT A CONGRESS THAT SUPPORTS THE PRESIDENT AND S.D.I., OR A CONGRESS THAT WANTS TO KEEP AMERICA VULNERABLE TO SOVIET NUCLEAR ATTACK?

PRESIDENT REAGAN'S STRATEGIC DEFENSE INITIATIVE

In March 1983, President Reagan proposed to the American people his Strategic Defense Initiative (SDI). SDI is a program to develop and build a means to destroy Soviet nuclear weapons before they can reach the United States. At the present time America has absolutely no defense against Soviet missiles. The SDI program is --

- Non-nuclear
- A substitute for the current doctrine of MAD (Mutual Assured Destruction). Rather than holding enemy civilians hostage to nuclear destruction, SDI is a program to defend the American people directly.
- A program of research and testing that includes:
 - Elements that could be deployed relatively soon, such as ground-based anti-missile missiles; and
 - Advanced elements that would need several years of research and testing, such as space-based lasers.
- A response to Soviet SDI efforts. The Soviets have been working on strategic defense much longer than the US and have invested more resources.

THE FIGHT IN CONGRESS

Ever since the President proposed SDI, liberal Democrats have been trying to kill or cripple the program.

- The Democrat-controlled House of Representatives has repeatedly cut SDI funding. For example -- In 1985, 97% of House Democrats voted for a measure to cut over \$1 billion from SDI.
- The Republican-controlled Senate has stood with the President and restored funds for SDI research.
- Incredibly, just before the President was leaving to meet with Gorbachev in Iceland, House Democrats froze SDI spending.
- Only at the very last minute, with the support of the Republican Senate, was the President able to force House Democrats to back down on their effort to undercut him at the negotiating table.

THE ICELAND SUMMIT

At Iceland the President pushed for deep cuts in nuclear arsenals while preserving our right to defend ourselves with SDI.

- The President put in front of the Soviets the most far-reaching arms proposal in the history of US-Soviet negotiations. This proposal would have:
 - Totally removed intermediate-range nuclear missiles from Europe;
 - Reduced by 50% all strategic arms stockpiles over the next 5 years, including bombers, air-launched cruise missiles, intercontinental ballistic missiles (ICBMs), submarine-launched ballistic missiles (SLBMs);
 - In the 5 years after that, eliminate all remaining offensive ballistic missiles of all ranges; while...
 - Permitting us to continue throughout the 10-year period with research, development, and testing of SDI within the confines of the 1972 ABM (Anti-Ballistic Missile) Treaty, after which...
 - Both the United States and the Soviet Union would be free to deploy defensive systems.
- The President's proposal would have been the first US/Soviet arms deal to actually reduce nuclear stockpiles.
- The President's proposal would have meant an orderly transfer from Mutual Assured Destruction to Mutual Assured Survival -- from offense to defense.
- The Soviets' response: NYET! General Secretary Gorbachev gave the President a demand: he would accept the President's proposal only if we agreed to kill SDI!
- The President refused to knuckle under to the Soviet ultimatum. He said:

"I had pledged to the American people that I would not trade away SDI -- there was no way I could tell our people their government would not protect them against nuclear destruction."

THE PRESIDENT DID THE RIGHT THING

The President made the right choice at Iceland and the American people know it. We need a Congress that will support the President and SDI.

- As the President said, SDI is our "insurance policy." It is the only way to force the Soviets to go ahead with any agreement to cut arms or to defend ourselves if they cheat.
- It was SDI that brought the Soviets to the table and forced them to talk about deep cuts. It will be SDI that forces them to keep their word when final agreement is reached.
- Mutual defense threatens no one. The fact that the Soviets were so adamant that we abandon our right to defend ourselves shows why we need SDI. In fact, the Soviets are hard at work on their own SDI!
- The President's action keeps the door open for real reductions. Our proposals for deep cuts are still on the table. The President said: "We are ready to go forward whenever and wherever the Soviets are ready. SDI is the key to a world without nuclear weapons."

POLLING DATA SHOW THE AMERICAN PEOPLE AGREE

The American people strongly support the President's decision at Iceland.

- A Washington Post-ABC News poll after the Iceland summit showed 64% approved of the President's handling of the meeting, while only 22% disapproved; a margin of almost 3 to 1. In addition, 55% approved his decision not to give up SDI; only 16% disapproved. [WP 10/16/86 p. A32]
- Similarly, a New York Times/CBS News poll showed that a whopping 68% approved his decision not to give up SDI, as opposed to 20%. [NYT 10/16/86 p. A11]
- And a Wall Street Journal/NBC News poll shows that by better than 4 to 1 margins the American people approved the President's actions at the summit. Fully 60% say we should develop SDI, with only 26% against. Moreover, 53% say it's important to elect members of Congress who will back the President on SDI. [WSJ 10/16/86 p. 68]

VOTERS SEE THROUGH ANTI-S.D.I. PROPAGANDA

Not only do Americans want SDI, but in-depth polling shows they reject many of the myths used to attack the program.

The following information is taken from a poll of 4,039 voters in 20 key Congressional districts across the nation, with at least 200 persons interviewed per district (Arthur J. Finkelstein & Associates poll for National Endowment for the Preservation of Liberty, July 1986):

Respondents in this poll:

- By a margin of almost 9 to 1 (87% to 10%) favored "the development of a defense system to protect the United States against a nuclear missile attack."
- By a margin of well over 2 to 1 (67.3% to 27%) would approve "an increase in defense spending to build a satellite system to protect the United States against nuclear missile attack."
- Reject MAD (Mutual Assured Destruction). By a margin of 6 to 1 (69.5% to 11.6%) would feel safer in a situation where both the US and the USSR had defense shields -- the President's proposal -- as opposed to the situation where each country were vulnerable to the other's nuclear weapons, as is the case today.
- Evenly split (43.7% to 42.9%) as to whether they know that the US currently has no defense against nuclear missiles. Upon being informed that such a defense does not now exist, a whopping 78.4% approved building such a defense.
- Are increasingly aware that the Soviets are doing their own work in strategic defense. By a margin of over 2 to 1 (56.4% to 27.6%) agree that "the Soviet Union will have a defense system capable of shooting down incoming nuclear missiles, regardless of what we do."
- Do not believe that SDI development would provoke the Soviets. By almost 2 to 1 (61.5% to 26.7%) disagree that "if the United States were to develop a defense system capable of defending against a nuclear attack, the Soviet Union would be more likely to attack the United States before the system was put in place."
- Only 26.8% (vs. 53.8%) are aware that SDI is a non-nuclear defense.
- By a huge margin (78.2% to 17.7%) believe that "the only lasting peace we can trust is if the United States can defend itself against any aggression." At the same time recognize (71.1% to 20.5%) that "at present, the United States is vulnerable to nuclear attack."
- Are worried not only about Soviet aggressiveness -- 28.1% think the USSR most likely to launch a missile attack -- but terrorists (30.9%) or another nation (24.2%). Only 4.4% think the United States most likely to launch a nuclear missile attack.
- SDI is good politics. By more than 7 to 1 (74.8% to 10.4%) would be more likely (as opposed to less likely) to vote for a Congressional candidate who supports SDI development.

Senate Republican Policy Committee
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